



Localisation: Ensuring Consistency in Localisation Through Style Guides

This article in the series deals with the topic of style guides for localisation.

According to Wikipedia, “A *style guide* or *style manual* is a set of standards for the writing and design of documents, either for general use or for a specific publication, organisation or field. [It helps] provide uniformity in style and formatting across multiple documents.”

I first learnt of style guides when my proposal for a conference research paper was accepted, and I was asked to send the complete paper as per their style guide. It consisted primarily of how to number sections, figures and references; the font sizes for headings of sections and subsections, as well as guidelines on other elements typical in a scientific publication.

In the context of localisation, we try to make a software application (or its documentation) developed for a *source* language appear equally natural for speakers of a *target* language. Languages differ in attributes, usage for communication, cultural elements, such as date formats, names of calendar elements and their short forms, and currency symbols. These need to be localised consistently. As the source language's elements and practices may have a different structure from the target language—or even be entirely absent in it—a style guide helps make the localisation

consistent, even if many people participate in the localisation. The style guide deals with language and cultural attributes, terminology and quality assessment aspects.

In the following sections, I will focus on the difficulties common to Indian language localisers. I encourage localisers to use the references for more information on specific languages. I have used the FUEL and Microsoft style guides for Telugu for illustration and highlight the improvements needed.

Let's look at some language and cultural attributes.

Product and feature names

As product and feature names are trademarked, some style guides advise against localising them. For one, the Microsoft Telugu style guide states that product names should not be localised. Here is an example why:

The Microsoft Feedback Tool is unable to send feedback.

(+) Translation: Microsoft ఫీడ్బ్యాక్ టూల్ సందేశం పంపలేకపోయింది.

From the viewpoint of user expectations, this is inappropriate. By transliterating *Microsoft* in Telugu as మైక్రోసాఫ్ట్, we do not violate any trademark rights. Actually, local